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SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 16, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Political divide widens at state line

In Trump 2.0 era, Illinois, Indiana take disparate approaches

By **Angie Leventis Lourgos**
Chicago Tribune

The Trump administration's surprise federal funding freeze met widespread condemnation in Illinois, as state leaders scrambled to fight the spending pause that spurred chaos and confusion prior to being temporarily blocked by a federal judge minutes before it was set to go into effect Jan. 28.

Gov. JB Pritzker vowed that Illinois would stand against the newly inaugurated president's attempt to potentially halt trillions of dollars in federal financial assistance, calling the move unlawful and a threat to millions of residents statewide.

"What Donald Trump tried to do in the last 24 hours was illegal," Pritzker said during a press conference that day. "Let's be clear: This is a demonstration of cruelty against people who depend on us."

Yet just over the border in Indiana, the top state official praised the austerity measure, which was designed to root out progressive agendas, promote efficiency and end "wokeness" through federal spending nationwide.

Republican Gov. Mike Braun thanked President Donald Trump for his "level of fiscal discipline," adding that the freeze was "in line with the values of Hoosiers" as well as the millions of Americans who elected the president to his second term.

"I applaud @realDonaldTrump's direction to pause government spending, fulfilling his campaign promise to rein in out-of-control government," Braun said in a post on social media site X that was liked 1,400 times. "I am confident we will continue to deliver needed services to Hoosiers with efficiency, doing more with less."

As the era of Trump 2.0 unfolds, the two neighboring states have taken disparate approaches to the whirlwind of change that's gripped American politics over the past few weeks.

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MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL



Former Illinois House Speaker Michael Madigan, accompanied by his daughter Nicole, leaves the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse in Chicago on Wednesday after jurors found him guilty on 10 counts in his racketeering case. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Case showcases pitfalls of state political culture

Conviction may give GOP path to relevancy, but obstacles exist

By **Rick Pearson**
Chicago Tribune

Michael Madigan's vaunted political skills were often likened to a grandmaster of the 3D chess board featured on the original "Star Trek" TV series in which he always appeared to be at least two moves ahead of his opponent.

That was until a federal court jury flipped the chessboard over on Wednesday when it convicted the former Democratic Illinois House speaker who served as the state's most powerful politician for decades.

Now, Republicans, the

minority party who portrayed Madigan as corrupt for years with muted success, have Madigan the convicted felon to feature in next year's state races, giving them an opening toward regaining some relevance in Springfield.

But their path is littered with obstacles, including the nationalizing of local elections that makes President Donald Trump, himself a convicted felon, a campaign issue for Republicans. There's also the partisan gerrymandered legislative district maps drawn by

Turn to **Republicans**, Page 12

Springfield no hotbed of reform, with feds often policing politicians

By **Ray Long, Jason Meisner and Megan Crepeau**
Chicago Tribune

Former House Speaker Michael Madigan's epic corruption conviction last week drew more than the usual level of outrage from public officials long accustomed to watching one of their own go down on criminal charges, but Gov. JB Pritzker issued a statement that came with a curious point.

"This week has been a vital reminder that we must maintain our vigilance in cleaning up government and always put the people we serve first," Illinois'

Democratic chief executive declared hours after the landmark verdict.

That is, of course, an appropriate remark, particularly for a governor with national ambitions. The verdict against Madigan, once the leader of the state's Democratic Party and the holder of a national record 36 years as speaker, could be viewed in many quarters as a vigilant effort to clean up government.

But the more than four-month trial that ended Wednesday once again shined a light on

Turn to **Trial**, Page 8

Activists anxiously await air pollution monitors



Anthony Moser and his daughters, Lucy, 10, foreground, and Sofia, 8, walk past the Corwith Intermodal Facility on their way to school Friday along Pershing Road and St. Louis Avenue in Chicago. Moser is an activist who has been involved in getting air quality information to the public. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Environmentalists hope Chicago is not backsliding on promises

By **John Lippert**
Chicago Tribune

Chicago is building what climate scientists say could be the country's best system for monitoring tailpipe pollution from diesel trucks. But even though the air monitors have arrived, the city doesn't expect to finish installing them for another year. Meanwhile, community members who are supposed to help operate the network and disseminate the findings are being asked to work for free when funding runs out.

In an email sent to community groups four days after President Donald Trump's inauguration, and later obtained by the Chicago Tribune, the city offered only its "hope" that data from the

Turn to **Monitors**, Page 2

INSIDE



CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Simple philosophy: Dunking is fun

Bulls rookie forward Matas Buzelis always believed that. Inside his preparation for the NBA Slam Dunk Contest. **Chicago Sports**

Zelenskyy calls for a European army

Says U.S. may no longer be counted on to support the continent. E.U. leaders bristle at U.S. approach to ending the war. **Nation & World**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 27 Low 2

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